Film Title

When (inciting incident),

(hero) struggles against (antagonistic force)

in order to (goal)

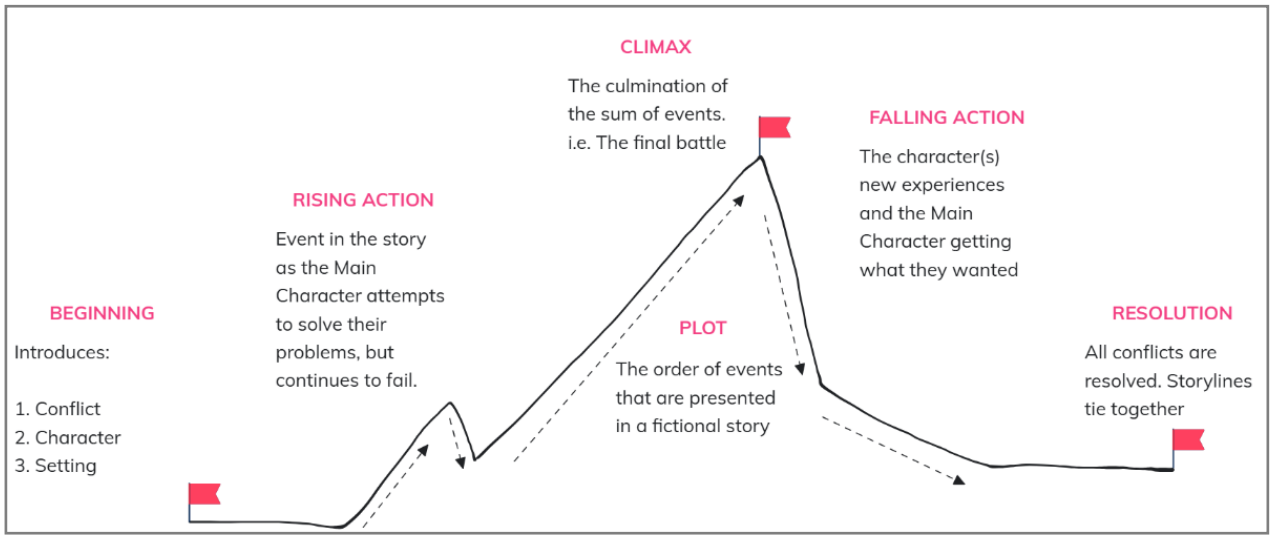
before (stakes are lost)

Author

Year

# Development

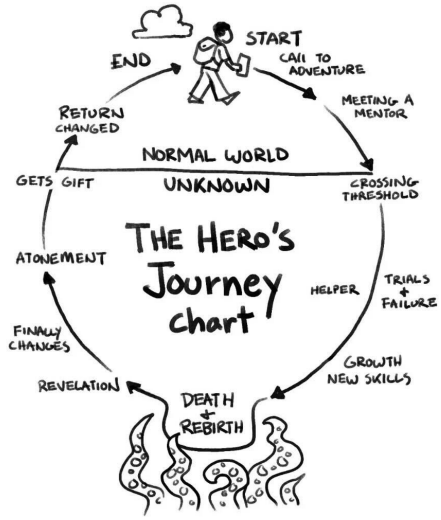
This phase of the production process includes fleshing out the story idea & writing a draft of the script.






Try listening to cinematic or orchestral music while you write.

- Soundtracks to movies ***you've never seen*** can be especially useful!
- Perhaps a genre or time period that inspires you.
- Imagine your character(s) in the music you hear. What might be happening?




Start

Call to Adventure

Meeting a Mentor

Crossing Threshold

Trials & Failure

Helper

Growth & New Skills

Death & Rebirth

Revelation

Finally Changes

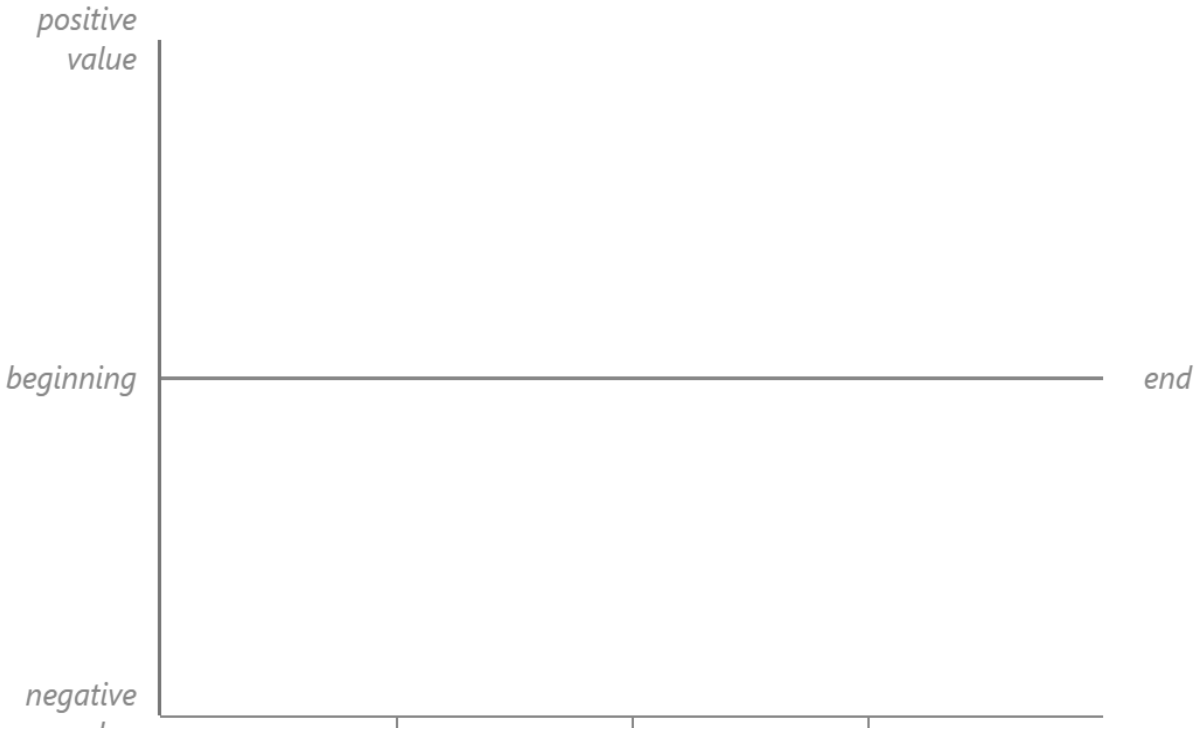
Atonement

Gets Gift

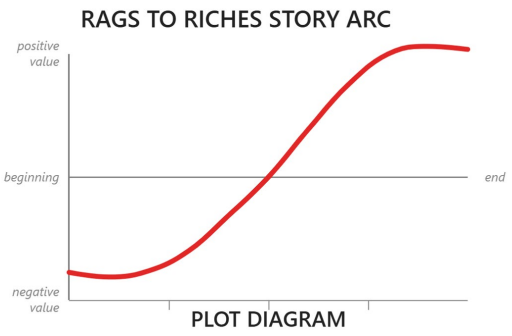
Return Changed

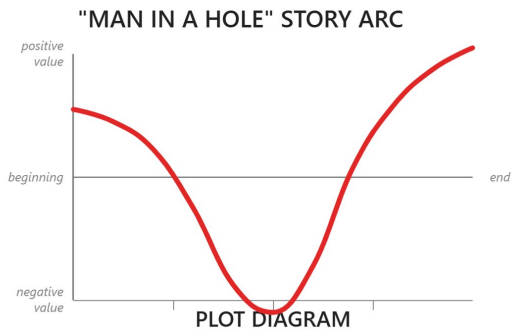
End

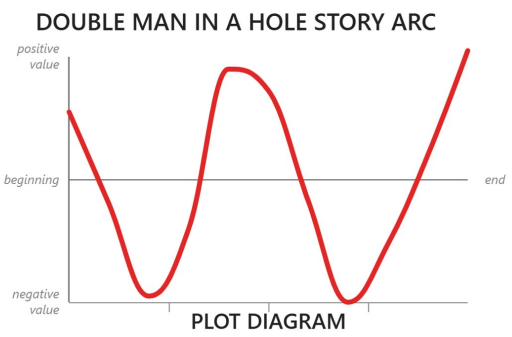
# Story Arc

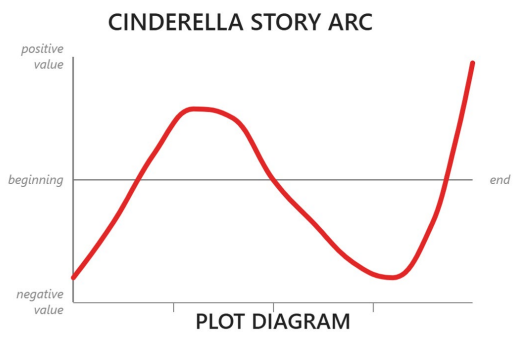



Examples



# Primary Character Arcs

| | Change | Steadfast |
|---|---|---|
| Positive | Name: _____<br>Name: _____<br>Name: _____ | Name: _____<br>Name: _____<br>Name: _____ |
| Negative | Name: _____<br>Name: _____<br>Name: _____ | Name: _____<br>Name: _____<br>Name: _____ |

Examples

| | Change | Steadfast |
|---|---|---|
| Positive |  |  |
| Negative |  |  |

# Brainstorming

## You can use some tools & techniques to brainstorm, by yourself or with help!

Activity Examples:

### Role on the wall

- Words or phrases describing the character are written directly onto the drawing or stuck on with sticky notes.

### Hot Seating

- One person embodies a character, who is questioned by the others about their background, behavior and motivation. It could be a primary, secondary

### Freeze Frames

- Participants freeze their bodies to create a scene. It's just like pressing pause on a video.

### Thought Tracking

- Characters in a freeze-frame speak their inner thoughts aloud. Very useful for turning images into scenes.

## Most involve an element of improvisation.

*Tina Fey's Rules of Improvisation That Will Change Your Life and Reduce Belly Fat**

1. The first rule of improvisation is AGREE. Always agree and SAY YES.
2. The second rule of improvisation is not only to say yes, but YES, AND. Agree and then add something of your own.
3. The next rule is MAKE STATEMENTS. This is a positive way of saying "Don't ask questions all the time."
4. THERE ARE NO MISTAKES, only opportunities

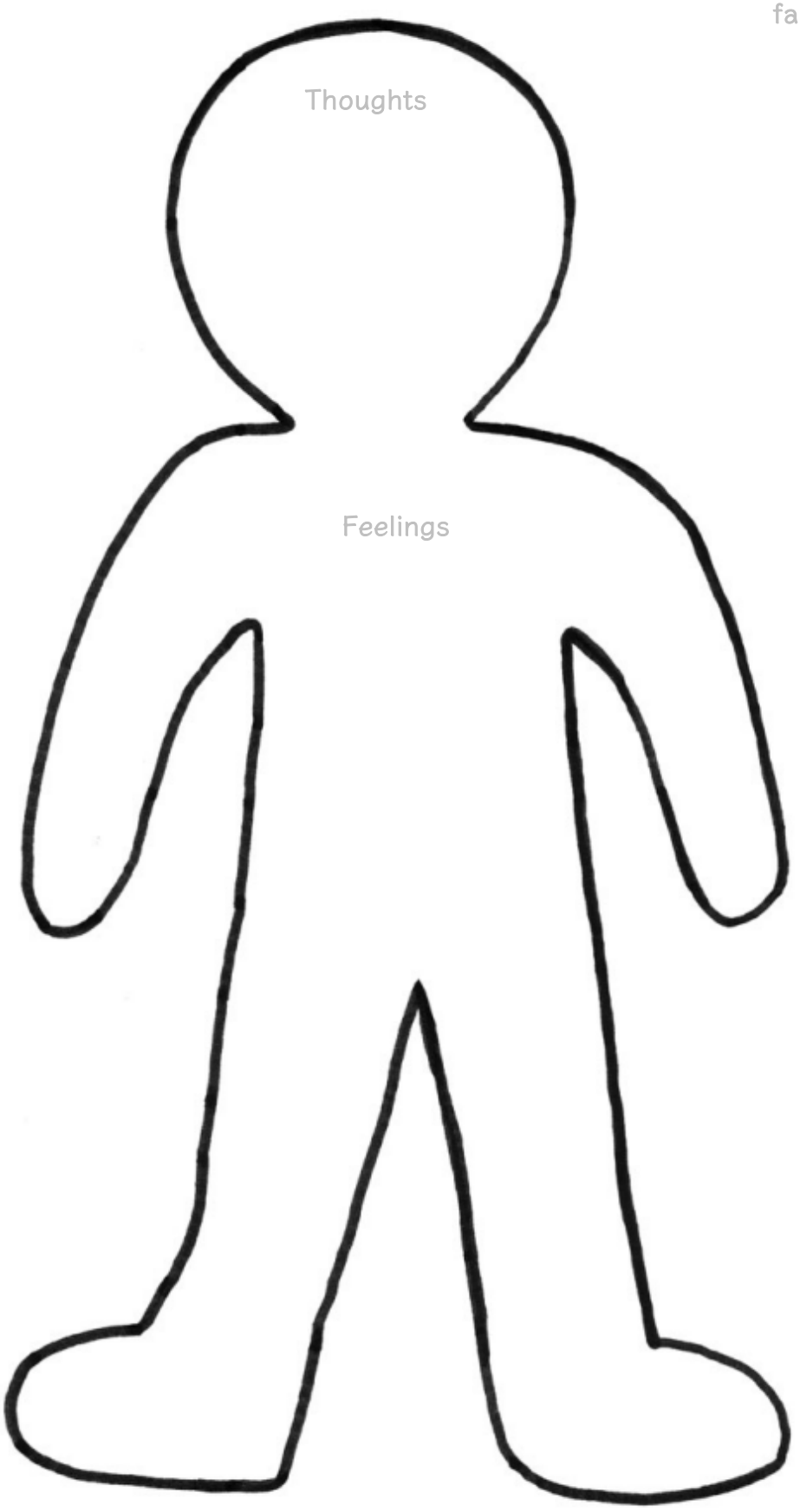
** Improv will not reduce belly fat*

*--From Bossypants by Tina Fey*

*Not everything has to be funny to be interesting.*

# Character: _____

Known facts



# Story Outline

**Brainstorm scenes using the 14 Hero's Journey beats before building your scene list or script.**

This section comes before your scene list and screenplay.

Each beat helps you brainstorm possible scenes, choices, conflicts, surprises, images, and character changes.

Later, you'll choose the strongest ideas and arrange them into a scene list.



Remember
- Some Ideas may disappear later, and that's ok.
- Focus on what the audience can see & hear!

*Step 1 of 14*

# Start

## Who's the story about?

What does everyday life look like / what should the audience know / what introduces the character's world?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Call to Adventure

**What problem or invitation pulls them into the story?**

What disrupts ordinary life / makes the story begin / can no longer be ignored?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Meeting a Mentor

## Who gives them advice, training, direction, or inspiration?

Who gives advice, training, direction, warning, encouragement, or inspiration?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

*Step 4 of 14*

# Crossing the Threshold

## What moment sends them into the unknown?

What choice commits them to the journey / creates a point of no return / moves them into a new situation?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Trials & Failure

## What challenge(s) force them to grow?

What obstacles test them / where do they fail or struggle / what shows difficulty instead of instant success?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# A Helper

## Who joins or supports them along the way?

Who stands with them / changes the journey / helps build an important relationship?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Growth

## What new skill, courage, or lesson do they gain?

What changes inside them / what do they learn to do or believe / how can growth be seen?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Death & Rebirth

## What is their lowest point, where they almost give up?

What feels lost / why does this moment hurt / what makes the audience wonder whether they will continue?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Revelation

## What truth do they finally understand?

What do they see clearly now / what were they wrong about before / what reveals the truth?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Finally Changes

## What choice proves they have changed?

What decision would they not have made at the beginning / what action proves the change / what shows the new self replacing the old self?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Atonement

## Who or what do they make right?

What relationship, mistake, or wrong must be repaired / who needs reconciliation or justice / what gets made right?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Gets Gift

## What have they gained, received, or brought back?

Is the gift an object, truth, skill, courage, relationship, or opportunity / how is it received or earned / why does it matter?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Return Changed

## How does everyday life show that they've changed?

Where do they return / how is normal life different now / what shows the change in action?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# End

## Who notices the change, and what is different going forward?

What final image summarizes the story / who recognizes the difference / what should the audience remember?

Scene Ideas

Notes, dialogue ideas, visual ideas, character moments

# Scene Planning

**Now, put your scene ideas into the order the audience will experience them. This becomes the map for your screenplay draft.**

How to use it

- List each scene in story order.
- Connect each scene to a journey step.
- Keep each scene description short.
- Combine scenes that do the same job.



Ask of every scene…

- Does something change?
- Does it reveal character?
- Does it move the story forward?
- Can the audience see or hear what happens?

# Scene List

| Scene # | Journey Step | Location | Characters | What Happens? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | | |
| 2 | | | | |
| 3 | | | | |
| 4 | | | | |
| 5 | | | | |
| 6 | | | | |
| 7 | | | | |
| 8 | | | | |
| 9 | | | | |
| 10 | | | | |
| 11 | | | | |
| 12 | | | | |
| 13 | | | | |
| 14 | | | | |
| 15 | | | | |
| 16 | | | | |
| 17 | | | | |

# Scene List (cont.)

| Scene # | Journey Step | Location | Characters | What Happens? |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 18 | | | | |
| 19 | | | | |
| 20 | | | | |
| 21 | | | | |
| 22 | | | | |
| 23 | | | | |
| 24 | | | | |
| 25 | | | | |
| 26 | | | | |
| 27 | | | | |
| 28 | | | | |
| 29 | | | | |
| 30 | | | | |
| 31 | | | | |
| 32 | | | | |
| 33 | | | | |
| 34 | | | | |

# Screenplay Guide

Advanced Guide

Screenplays use special formatting so a film crew can quickly understand what appears on screen.

## Screenplay Vocabulary Guide

| | |
|---|---|
| **FADE IN:** | The screen begins black, then the image slowly appears. |
| **FADE OUT:** | The image fades away. Often used at the end. |
| **INT.** | Interior. The scene is inside. |
| **EXT.** | Exterior. The scene is outside. |
| **Slugline (Scene Heading)** | The line that tells where and when the scene happens. |
| **Action** | What the audience can see or hear, usually in present tense. |
| **Character Cue** | The name of the character speaking, usually centered and capitalized. |
| **Dialogue** | The words the character says. |
| **Parenthetical** | A short note about how a line is said or what the character is doing. |
| **V.O.** | Voice-over: A voice the audience hears that is not visible in the scene. |
| **O.S.** | Off-screen. The character is in the scene but not visible. |
| **SUPER** | Text appears over the image, like a date, place, or title card. |

## Simple Example

```
FADE IN:

EXT. FOREST PATH - DAY

A young boy runs through the trees, clutching a torn map.

JONAH
Wait for me!

He trips, falls, and looks back toward the sound of footsteps.

SUPER: THREE HOURS EARLIER
```

Write what the audience can see and hear. Save long explanations for your outline notes, not the screenplay page.